

ETS contrail measures under the radar

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Navigating the complex world of EU mobility policy and infrastructure. By JORDYN DAHL with TOMMASO LECCA and MARTINA SAPIO SNEAK PEEK — The European C

Navigating the complex world of EU mobility policy and infrastructure.

By JORDYN DAHL

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SNEAK PEEK

- The European Commission is proposing to reward airlines that adopt contrail-avoidance strategies, but experts question whether the incentives will be large enough.
- Commission President Ursula von der Leyen zeroed in on the bloc's competitiveness challenges and how to tackle Chinese imports in a closely watched speech.
- Greece has signed up to the EU's common position on the IMO's Net-Zero Framework ahead of next week's shipping climate talks, even as its powerful domestic shipping industry campaigns against the framework.

Good morning, and welcome to Morning Mobility.

Mark your calendars: Our weekly mobility calendar landed in your inbox on Thursday. You can also go online to export and plan your week or suggest your own event.

Tips to jdahl@politico.eu , tlecca@politico.eu and msapio@politico.eu . Follow us @tommylecca , @jordyndahl and @martsapio .

DRIVING THE DAY

ETS REVIEW'S CONTRAIL MEASURES UNDER THE SPOTLIGHT: The European Commission's proposed review of the Emissions Trading System includes new incentives to tackle aviation's non-CO2 climate effects, but some experts consider these measures too small to make a difference. Aviation accounts for around 2.5 percent of global CO2 emissions, but its overall contribution to global warming is estimated to be around twice as large because of non-CO2 emissions.

What are contrails? Part of aviation's climate impact comes from contrails , short for condensation trails — the white lines left behind aircraft in the sky, consisting mainly of condensed water vapor. Some persistent contrails contribute to warming by trapping heat in the atmosphere, an effect that can potentially be reduced by adjusting flight paths.

Under the current rules, airlines already have to monitor and report the non-CO2 effects of their intra-European flights. The ETS review proposes a new financial incentive — up to 3 million ETS

allowances through the end of 2033 — for carriers that incorporate contrail forecasting into flight planning and, where possible, adjust routes to avoid creating climate-warming contrails.

Peanuts for airlines: However, an analysis by contrail-mitigation firms Estuaire and Nexus Lab found that the proposed incentive would provide the airline sector with less than €6 million a year for contrail avoidance.

“It’s going to be difficult to incentivize airlines to integrate contrail avoidance into the flight-planning software from this little money,” said Joachim Majholm from Blue Lines, an NGO that raises awareness about contrails. According to Majholm, most flight-planning software currently used by airlines does not include contrail-avoidance capabilities, while the proposed ETS incentives are too small to encourage investment in them.

Potential extra costs: Avoiding contrails can also come at a price. Airlines “sometimes have to spend a little bit more fuel,” Majholm said, potentially increasing both their largest operating cost and their ETS compliance costs because of the additional CO₂ emissions. “The math doesn’t really add up,” Majholm told Tommaso about the Commission proposal.

Air traffic controllers could also play an important role in contrail avoidance, for example “through operational strategies to re-route flights away from ice supersaturated regions, where persistent contrails typically form,” said Enrico Parini, director of European affairs at Canso Europe, which represents air navigation service providers.

Missing elements: But such measures “require many elements, which are not yet fully addressed,” Parini said. These include combining accurate meteorological forecasts with flight information, ensuring that any additional CO₂ generated by rerouting does not outweigh the climate benefits of avoiding contrails, and accounting for the potential costs for air traffic management providers.

Small steps welcomed: “As the near-term climate impact of contrails can be at least as great as that of carbon emissions, it is understandable that the EU wishes to address this,” Parini told Tommaso. “It is however appropriate that the proposal should start with small steps, as contrail mitigation strategies are still in the trial phase,” he added, noting that they must be integrated “without compromising safety and while also considering the impact this may have on [air traffic] capacity.”

CARS

HOW DOES VOLKSWAGEN GET OUT OF ITS CRISIS: Your anchor went on U.K. radio show Monocle on Thursday to discuss the crisis at Volkswagen and how Germany’s politicians are responding. CEO Oliver Blume wrapped up his visit to VW factories on Wednesday, but his deputies are continuing the tour with a visit today. It’s the last opportunity to go before the workers before a showdown on Sept. 4 between the board and the union.

What’s happening: Blume will again put his cost-cutting plan to a vote. An earlier vote in July failed to pass. The worker’s council has strongly resisted the cuts and factory closures, and they have an ally in Olaf Lies, the Lower Saxony premier who sits on VW’s advisory board. Earlier this week, Lies told VW workers that he would resist the measures.

What comes next: Carsten Breski, chief economist of ING Germany, came on the Monocle program as well, suggesting that the German government could implement a bailout of sorts to rescue the industry.

No silver bullet: Such a plan would not solve Volkswagen's dwindling market share in China — its largest and most important market. "The German government can do whatever it wants, but the market in China is so severely competitive, which means they can only buy some time for Volkswagen. But the innovation needs to come from Volkswagen and from the European automotive sector itself," Brzeski said.

[Listen to the full episode here](#) .

SETTING THE STAGE FOR CHINA POLICY: European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen zeroed in on the bloc's competitiveness challenges, and how to tackle Chinese imports in a closely watched speech to the French patronnat on Thursday.

Let's not rock the boat: But von der Leyen also struck a balanced tone toward China, as Brussels is now entering a tight calendar ahead of an October summit where her institution will be expected to present "tangible results" to EU leaders, following the engagement with the Chinese side last June.

Reminder: German Chancellor Friedrich Merz promised on Wednesday to put forward Berlin's proposal in October for how to tackle competition with China, particularly the onslaught of plug-in hybrids that are not covered under the made-in-China EV duties. Germany has historically taken a more conciliatory tone toward China over fear of retribution from Beijing against its automakers. But the automotive crisis and declining market share has changed that calculation.

Carrots... "China is a key economic partner. And our approach is clear and consistent: derisking without breaking ties," von der Leyen said in her speech.

And sticks: "Dialogue with China remains necessary. But it must produce results. And when dialogue is not enough, we must be ready to make full use of our instruments," she added, vowing to "step up investigations significantly."

The bottom line: Those words are expected to be an appetizer paving the way to her big State of the European Union speech in mid-September, when the Commission's president is poised to give the contours of the EU's next steps toward Beijing, our colleague Camille Gijs reports.

MARITIME

GREECE FALLS IN LINE AT IMO: Greece has signed up to the EU's common position on the IMO's Net-Zero Framework ahead of next week's crucial shipping climate talks, even as its powerful domestic shipping industry campaigns against the framework.

The EU line: Athens is now formally back alongside its European partners after months of ambiguous positioning, including abstaining from the last vote in November. Greece's shipowners, however, are heading in the opposite direction: Union of Greek Shipowners President Melina Travlos this week backed an alternative pushed by Panama and Liberia.

[Martina has more here](#) .

EUROPE RISKS MISSING THE ARCTIC BOAT: China's new scheduled shipping route through the Russian Arctic could give Beijing a strategic advantage in reaching Europe during future trade disruptions, while leaving European operators reliant on a corridor ultimately controlled by Moscow, Bruegel economist Alicia García-Herrero told Martina.

Russia holds the keys: Chinese carrier Sea Legend is launching regular services to Northern Europe through Russia's Northern Sea Route, promising journeys of around 20 days. But García-Herrero stressed that Moscow controls the commercially relevant stretch, including permits and access, potentially giving it the power to favor Chinese operators.

Not about volume: The route remains seasonal and cannot rival the Suez Canal in scale. Its strategic value, García-Herrero argues, is instead as an "insurance" route that could give China faster access to Europe when traditional shipping corridors are disrupted.

Europe's problem: That could leave European companies at a disadvantage on a trade route ending on their own doorstep. With Brussels currently reviewing its Arctic policy, García-Herrero argued Europe should develop alternatives rather than simply watch the China-Russia corridor take shape.

THIRD RUSSIAN LNG TANKER HEADS FOR FAYARD: A third specialized tanker carrying LNG from Russia's Yamal project is preparing to enter Denmark's Fayard shipyard for maintenance, escalating a political row over the last known EU yard still servicing the vessels before a European ban takes effect next year.

Last maintenance window: The vessel follows the Rudolf Samoylovich and Georgiy Brusilov into Fayard this summer. Campaigners argue that servicing the specialized ice-class tankers now could keep them operating for years after the EU ban on providing maintenance and other services to Russian LNG tankers takes effect on Jan. 1.

Awkward timing: Fayard is also due to exhibit next week at the Pavilion of Denmark at the SMM maritime trade fair in Hamburg, which is co-financed by Denmark's foreign ministry. Campaigners from Urgewald are calling on the ministry to review the shipyard's participation.

Headlines

Here's a recap of yesterday's news, along with Pro articles and alerts from overnight.

The auto industry is at the center of Trump's trade war. They want a way out.

The president has threatened to raise tariffs on automobiles and parts to 50 percent if Canada and the U.S. can't strike a deal by Jan. 1.

By Daniel Desrochers, Oliver Ward · Aug 27, 2026, 10:42 pm Europe/Brussels CEST

Document: Greece signs EU shipping emissions position despite industry opposition

Athens has signed onto Brussels' common position on decarbonizing shipping — even as the country's powerful shipowners campaign for a rival plan to weaken the rules.

By Martina Sapio · Aug 27, 2026, 08:52 pm Europe/Brussels CEST

Weekly Calendar

Here's a selection of upcoming key events, find the complete Week Ahead online.

ACI World Airport Experience Summit

Aug 31, 2026, 9:00 AM - Sep 4, 2026, 5:00 PM · Istanbul, TR

Council Working Party on Space

Sep 1, 2026 · Brussels, BE

Coreper II

Sep 2, 2026 · Brussels, BE

Pro Intelligence Connections

2021/0211(COD) Revision of the EU Emissions Tradin...

Discussions within the Council or its preparatory...

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